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As the campaign for the presidency got under way late that summer in 1980, Americans for a second year in a row were trying to cope with the ruthless effects of double-digit inflation, which was eating away at their savings, their paychecks, and their way of life like a horde of locusts. Interest rates were over fifteen percent, depriving millions of American families of a chance to buy a home; in countless communities, the unemployment rate, like inflation and interest rates, was in double digits.

Militarily, our nation was seriously in danger of falling behind the Soviet Union at a time a former naval officer was holding the watch as Commander in Chief. The Soviets were modernizing their fleet and their ground and air forces on a massive scale. Yet on any given day, I was told as many as half the ships in our navy couldn't leave port because of a lack of spare parts or crew and half our military aircraft couldn't fly for lack of spare parts; the overwhelming majority of our military enlisted personnel were high school dropouts.

Abroad, the Soviet Union was engaged in a brutal war in Afghanistan and Communism was extending its tentacles deep into Central America and Africa. In Iran, more than fifty Americans had been held captive for almost a year under the regime of a vicious religious despot who had risen to power while an old and loyal ally of the United States had been forced from power and our country had done nothing to help him.

I made a decision not to criticize President Carter regarding Iran. I knew anything I might say could interfere with efforts to free the hostages. Being governor had taught